

Personal Statement

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Academics have always been a strong emphasis in my household. Both of my parents immigrated to the United States with hopes of better opportunities and economic freedom. While my mother graduated from National Chengchi University in Taiwan, my father was never able to complete college. Despite his passion for education and acceptance into National Taiwan University as an electrical engineering major, he left school to help his family build a new life in the United States as restaurant owners. Growing up, I watched my father work twelve hours a day, seven days a week. To financially support our family, he sacrificed both his personal aspirations and time with me and my sisters. In the rare moments we shared, he often reminded me that education would be my pathway to success. Witnessing his dedication deeply ingrained this belief in me.

From elementary through high school, I pursued academic excellence relentlessly, earning top grades and enrolling in advanced courses. I became so focused on GPA that I frequently chose weighted AP classes over subjects I found more interesting or practical, simply to preserve my record. At the same time, I volunteered as a tutor for both the National Honor Society and the Voices for Children Advocacy Center in Flint. Supporting students—whether a high schooler struggling with Algebra or a middle schooler with reading disabilities—gave me perspective on the privilege I held in my own education. These experiences taught me gratitude, but also fueled the pressure I placed on myself as I entered college.

At Michigan, I continued my streak of straight A's, but the pressure to maintain perfection became overwhelming. When I overslept the final exam in EECS 485 and earned my first A-, my sense of identity began to unravel. I was devastated, but a conversation with my parents helped me reset. They reminded me that mistakes are inevitable and that grades alone do not determine my future. Although I had long felt the pressure of defining myself through grades, it was this experience that made the issue impossible to ignore and motivated me to take action. Rather than continuing to chase grades as though they were the ultimate goal, my pursuit shifted towards personal growth, self-expression, and discovery.

Since then, I have redefined how I measure success. My academic journey is not solely about transcripts; it is about the lessons, resilience, and purpose that guide me. Because of my father's sacrifices, I have the freedom to pursue my dreams wholeheartedly. I want to use this opportunity to push my limits in AI and XR, fields that are rapidly shaping the future and have immense potential to help others. As a software engineer, I aspire to build a career that excites me—one where I can work with innovative technologies, think creatively, and develop tangible

tools that improve people's lives. Graduate study in CSE will not only equip me to launch this career but also allow me to honor my family's sacrifices by striving for impact beyond myself.